

User Personas

University Course Feedback Analytics Platform

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Persona 1: Dr. Sarah Chen - Faculty Member

Demographics

Name: Dr. Sarah Chen

Age: 45

Role: Associate Professor of Computer Science

Experience: 15 years in higher education

Teaching Load: 3 courses per semester (Database Design, Web Technologies, Senior Capstone)

Class Size: 80-120 students per course

Professional Background

PhD in Computer Science from top university

Published 12+ peer-reviewed papers

Active in faculty governance; serves on curriculum committee

Mentors junior faculty on teaching effectiveness

Motivations & Goals

Primary Goal: Understand how students perceive her teaching and identify specific areas for improvement

Secondary Goals:

Document teaching effectiveness for tenure/promotion portfolio

Share successful strategies with colleagues

Create course improvements that benefit students

Current Situation & Pain Points

Currently receives feedback via email (bulk downloads from university survey system)

Feedback arrives in unstructured format; difficult to spot patterns

Takes 2-3 hours to manually analyze and categorize feedback

Unsure which feedback is most important or representative

No easy way to track improvements semester-over-semester

Cannot easily respond to student concerns or acknowledge feedback

How She Uses the System

Logs in at semester start to review previous semester's feedback
Checks dashboard 1-2 times per month to see new feedback trickling in
Reviews latest comments during office hours to address specific concerns
Uses trend data to inform course redesign for next semester
Exports summary report for promotion portfolio

Key Needs from the System

Dashboard: Clear visualization of course metrics (ratings, sentiment distribution, response rate)
Comments: Latest student feedback displayed with sentiment tags (positive/negative)
Trends: Semester-over-semester comparison (was I better or worse than last time?)
Actionability: Specific recommendations on what to improve (e.g., "pacing is too fast")
Time: Takes <5 minutes to extract meaningful insights

Success Metrics for Dr. Chen

Identifies 2-3 specific improvements to implement next semester
Responds to critical feedback within 7 days
Semester-over-semester satisfaction rating improves by ≥ 0.2 points
Uses system data to document teaching effectiveness for promotion

Technology Comfort Level: High (faculty member in CS; familiar with dashboards and data visualization)

Potential Objections / Concerns

"Will feedback be truly anonymous? Students might be harsh if they fear retribution."

"This adds more work to my plate; it better be easy to use."

"How can I tell if feedback is legitimate or just from a few disgruntled students?"

Quote: "I want to know what my students really think so I can be a better teacher. But I need it presented clearly—I don't have time to dig through 200 comments."

Persona 2: Alex Rodriguez - Student

Demographics

Name: Alex Rodriguez

Age: 20

Year: Junior (3rd year)

Major: Business Administration

Enrolled Courses: 4 per semester (mix of major and electives)

Tech Savvy: Very high (digital native, active on social media)

Student Background

First-generation college student; highly motivated

Works part-time job (15 hours/week); limited free time

Active in student organizations; values peer feedback

Concerned about course selection and teaching quality

Values instructors who are responsive and care about student learning

Motivations & Goals

Primary Goal: Help instructors improve by providing honest feedback

Secondary Goals:

Make informed decisions about which courses/instructors to take

See that feedback leads to real improvements

Contribute to campus improvement efforts

Current Situation & Pain Points

Receives feedback surveys via email; typically 2-3 per semester

Surveys feel like "a dead end"—never sees what happens with feedback

Worried about anonymity; concerned feedback could affect grades

Finds long surveys tedious; loses interest mid-survey

Has no way to see feedback about a course before enrolling

Previous feedback experiences felt impersonal and disconnected

How He Uses the System

Receives notification (email or course page) about feedback survey

Completes 5-minute survey while taking a break between classes

(Ideally) Receives confirmation that feedback is anonymous
Later: Reviews feedback on course pages to inform future enrollment decisions
Notices improvements instructors make based on feedback

Key Needs from the System

Simplicity: Survey should take <5 minutes to complete
Assurance: Clear statement that feedback is anonymous (no names collected)
Impact: Visibility into how feedback led to improvements
Accessibility: Mobile-friendly; works on phone during free time
Visibility: Can see aggregated feedback on courses before enrolling

Success Metrics for Alex

Completes 2-3 feedback surveys per semester (up from current 1-2)
Confidence in anonymity is high (scores 4-5 on 5-point scale)
Uses feedback summaries to inform at least 1 course choice per year
Notices and appreciates improvements instructors implement

Technology Comfort Level: Very High (social media user; expects mobile-first experience)

Potential Objections / Concerns

"I'm worried the system isn't really anonymous. What if my professor figures out it was me?"

"This is just another survey that won't go anywhere. Why should I bother?"

"If I'm brutally honest about poor instruction, will it hurt my grade?"

Quote: "I'll give feedback if I know it's really anonymous and if I see that instructors actually use it to improve."

Persona 3: Dr. James Mitchell - Department Chair

Demographics

Name: Dr. James Mitchell

Age: 58

Role: Department Chair (Computer Science)

Experience: 20 years faculty; 8 years as department chair

Responsibilities: 12 courses, 18 faculty, budget management, curriculum oversight

Professional Background

Senior faculty with strong reputation in field

Administrative experience: previously served on academic council

Strategic thinker; focused on continuous improvement

Balances faculty interests with student success

Motivations & Goals

Primary Goal: Ensure teaching quality is high and continuously improving across the department

Secondary Goals:

Identify struggling courses early and provide targeted support

Allocate professional development resources strategically

Recognize and reward high performers

Inform curriculum decisions with data

Prepare for accreditation reviews with evidence of teaching quality

Current Situation & Pain Points

Feedback data arrives in disparate formats from different sources

Manual compilation of feedback takes 10+ hours per semester

Cannot easily see trends across courses or identify patterns

Reports from survey vendor are outdated by the time he receives them

Difficult to compare courses (different instructors, different cohorts)

No proactive alerting system; discovers problems reactively

Struggles to justify PD budget allocations without clear data

How He Uses the System

Logs in mid-semester to monitor feedback trends
Reviews dashboard showing all courses (alert panel shows any below-threshold courses)
Identifies 1-2 struggling courses for intervention/support
Pulls detailed feedback for course/faculty to understand root causes
At semester end, generates comprehensive report for dean
Uses data to allocate PD resources, recommend new course designs, make staffing decisions

Key Needs from the System

Automated Reporting: System-wide report generation (semester, year-over-year)
Real-Time Alerts: Notification when course satisfaction drops below threshold
Drill-Down Capability: Start with university overview → department → course → individual feedback
Comparison Tools: Compare courses, track faculty improvements, benchmark against peer departments
Export: Export data for presentations to accreditation bodies and upper administration
Efficiency: Generate comprehensive report in <1 hour (currently takes 10+ hours)

Success Metrics for Dr. Mitchell

Semester report generation time reduced from 10+ hours to <1 hour
Identifies struggling courses within 2 weeks of semester start (vs. end of semester now)
Proactively allocates PD resources based on feedback data
Demonstrates teaching quality improvement to accreditation bodies
Faculty appreciation for targeted, data-driven support

Technology Comfort Level: Medium (comfortable with dashboards; prefers intuitive UI over technical details)

Potential Objections / Concerns

"This better not add to my workload. I'm already stretched thin."
"I need to be able to drill down to understand issues, but I don't want to drown in data."
"Faculty will be concerned if this feels like surveillance. How do we ensure trust?"

Quote: "I need to know what's happening in my department in real time so I can support faculty and help struggling courses before students suffer."

Persona 4: Maya Patel - Dean of Academic Affairs

Demographics

Name: Maya Patel

Age: 52

Role: Dean of Academic Affairs

Experience: 25 years in higher education; 6 years as dean

Responsibilities: 4 departments, 150+ courses, 80+ faculty, strategic planning

Professional Background

PhD in Higher Education Administration

Published research on teaching effectiveness and student outcomes

Strong advocate for data-driven decision making

Reports to Provost; influences institutional strategy

Experienced in accreditation and strategic planning

Motivations & Goals

Primary Goal: Optimize teaching quality institution-wide to improve student learning outcomes and accreditation standing

Secondary Goals:

Support faculty development and recognize excellence

Inform curriculum and hiring decisions

Track progress on teaching quality initiatives

Demonstrate institutional commitment to quality (for rankings, accreditation)

Build culture of continuous improvement

Current Situation & Pain Points

Teaching quality data scattered across departments; manual aggregation required

Department chairs use different metrics and formats; difficult to compare

Year-over-year trend analysis is manual and time-consuming

Cannot quickly identify institution-wide issues or emerging patterns

Strategic planning is hampered by lack of clear data on teaching quality

Accreditation bodies request teaching effectiveness data; currently hard to demonstrate

Competitive pressure from peer institutions; lacking benchmarking capability

How She Uses the System

Quarterly review: logs into institutional dashboard to check KPI progress
Views year-over-year trends (has satisfaction improved? where?)
Identifies departments needing additional support or investment
Pulls detailed data to inform discussions with department chairs
Uses system data in strategic planning meetings and accreditation submissions
Prepares presentations for provost and board meetings with real data

Key Needs from the System

Institutional View: Dashboard showing teaching quality across entire university
Multi-Year Trends: Track progress over 3-5 years; identify long-term patterns
Department Comparison: Compare departments and identify best practices
Alert System: Proactive notification of systemic issues
Export & Visualization: Professional reports and charts for presentations
Drill-Down: Detail enough to understand root causes, not overwhelmed by data
Benchmarking: If possible, compare to peer institutions

Success Metrics for Maya

Strategic decisions (hiring, curriculum, PD budget) informed by teaching quality data
Year-over-year teaching quality improvements tracked and communicated
Accreditation reviewers impressed by quality assurance data
Faculty and students report higher satisfaction with teaching/learning
Teaching quality becomes measurable component of institutional strategy

Technology Comfort Level: High (expects enterprise-grade analytics; wants high-level insights with drill-down capability)

Potential Objections / Concerns

"I need to see ROI on this system. Show me how it improves student outcomes."

"Data integrity is critical. How do we ensure the numbers are reliable?"

"This system better integrate with our existing reporting infrastructure."

Quote: "I want one source of truth for teaching quality across our institution. Right now I'm flying blind, making decisions with incomplete data."

Persona Comparison Matrix

Aspect	Dr. Sarah Chen	Alex Rodriguez	Dr. James Mitchell	Maya Patel
Primary Need	Personal feedback + trends	Simple survey + transparency	Department overview + alerts	Institution-wide data + trends
Frequency of Use	1-2x/month	2-3x/semester	2x/month	Quarterly
Time Availability	Low (teaching-focused)	Very low (student + job)	Medium (administrative)	Medium (strategic focus)
Data Depth	Medium (own course)	Low (summary only)	High (department)	High (institution)
Tech Comfort	High	Very High	Medium	High
Key Frustration	Manual data analysis	Unclear impact	Manual reporting	Lack of unified data
Success = ?	Course improvement	Real feedback impact	Time savings + better decisions	Strategic data-driven decisions

User Persona Journeys

Dr. Sarah Chen's Semester Journey

Aug (Semester Start)

- └ Reviews previous Spring feedback
- └ Plans course improvements based on feedback
- └ Sets personal teaching goals

Sep-Nov (During Semester)

- └ Checks dashboard monthly for feedback trends
- └ Responds to critical comments
- └ Adjusts course in real-time based on feedback

Dec (Semester End)

- └ Reviews comprehensive semester report
- └ Meets with department chair to discuss improvements
- └ Plans Spring course revisions

Jan (Promotion/Tenure Documentation)

- └ Exports feedback summary and KPI data for portfolio

Alex Rodriguez's Feedback Journey

Week 1-5 of Course

- └ Sees feedback survey notification in course email

Week 6 (Feedback Window)

- └ Completes 5-minute survey on phone during free time
- └ Receives confirmation: "Your feedback is anonymous"
- └ Feels good about contributing

Week 7-15 (Rest of Semester)

- └ Sees feedback summary on course page; notes feedback themes

Week 16+ (After Course)

- └ When choosing courses for next semester, checks course feedback pages
- └ Makes enrollment decision partly based on feedback ("Good pacing" vs "Too fast")
- └ Confident that feedback will actually matter next semester

Dr. Mitchell's Semester Management

Aug (Pre-Semester Planning)

- └ Reviews previous year's feedback by course
- └ Plans professional development initiatives

Sep (Monitoring Begins)

- └ Dashboard shows first submissions trickling in
- └ No immediate concerns

Oct (Mid-Semester)

- └ Alert: Database Design satisfaction at 3.2 (below 3.5 threshold)
- └ Contacts faculty: "Let's discuss student concerns"
- └ Plan together: adjust pacing, add office hours

Nov (Follow-Up)

- └ New feedback shows improvement (satisfaction at 3.7)
- └ Recognizes faculty for course improvements
- └ Shares strategy with other faculty

Dec (Semester End)

- └ Generates comprehensive report (1 hour, not 10+ hours!)
- └ Presents findings to dean
- └ Plans next year's PD and curriculum initiatives

Maya Patel's Annual Strategic Cycle

Jan (Strategic Planning)

- └ Reviews institution-wide teaching quality data from previous year
- └ Compares departments
- └ Identifies trends (e.g., "Sentiment improving overall")

Mar (Mid-Year)

- └ Quarterly review of KPIs
- └ Alerts show any emerging issues
- └ Adjusts PD budget allocation if needed

Jun (Accreditation Planning)

- └ Exports teaching quality reports
- └ Prepares presentation on continuous improvement
- └ Shows multi-year trends to accreditation body

Dec (Annual Review)

- └ Full-year report on teaching quality initiatives
- └ Year-over-year comparison shows improvements
- └ Informs strategic planning for next year
- └ Reports success to Provost and Board

Persona Empathy Map

Dr. Sarah Chen

Thinks: "My students' learning is my responsibility. I need to know what's not working."

Feels: Committed to excellence; frustrated by manual processes; eager to improve

Hears: Peer stories about positive feedback; student comments

Sees: Email with feedback; course enrollments change

Says: "I want clear insights without extra work"

Does: Reviews feedback, adjusts course, documents improvements

Pains: Time spent analyzing; unclear priorities; hard to track improvements

Gains: Satisfied students; course improvements; tenure documentation

Alex Rodriguez

Thinks: "My feedback matters; I want to see real improvements"

Feels: Appreciated when heard; frustrated when feedback seems ignored; worried about anonymity

Hears: Peer concerns about courses; professor acknowledgment of feedback

Sees: Course pages with feedback; survey invitations; improvements (or lack thereof)

Says: "I'll give honest feedback if it's anonymous and makes a difference"

Does: Completes survey; checks course feedback before enrolling; evaluates improvements

Pains: Survey fatigue; anonymity concerns; unclear impact of feedback

Gains: Influenced course improvements; better course choices; voice heard

Dr. Mitchell

Thinks: "Teaching quality is critical; I need complete visibility across my department"

Feels: Responsible for faculty support; eager to identify and fix problems; overwhelmed with data

Hears: Faculty concerns; dean expectations; accreditation questions

Sees: Department performance data; struggling courses; faculty needs

Says: "I need comprehensive data without drowning in details"

Does: Reviews feedback, supports struggling courses, allocates resources, generates reports

Pains: Manual reporting (10+ hours); reactive problem discovery; data silos

Gains: Proactive problem-solving; data-driven decisions; faculty support

Maya Patel

Thinks: "Teaching quality drives institutional excellence and student success"

Feels: Responsible for institution-wide improvement; need for robust data; pressure for accreditation

Hears: Board expectations; peer comparisons; accreditation standards

Sees: Department performance trends; strategic opportunities

Says: "I need institutional data to drive strategic decisions"

Does: Reviews trends, informs strategy, allocates resources, prepares accreditation reports

Pains: Fragmented data; lack of trends; manual processes; limited benchmarking

Gains: Data-driven strategy; continuous improvement; accreditation success

How Personas Interact

Dr. Chen receives feedback from: Alex Rodriguez and other students

Dr. Chen reports to: Dr. James Mitchell

Dr. Mitchell reports to: Maya Patel

Alex Rodriguez benefits from: Dr. Chen's improvements based on Alex's feedback

This creates a virtuous cycle where student feedback drives faculty improvement, which is monitored by department leadership and reflected in institutional strategy.

The End